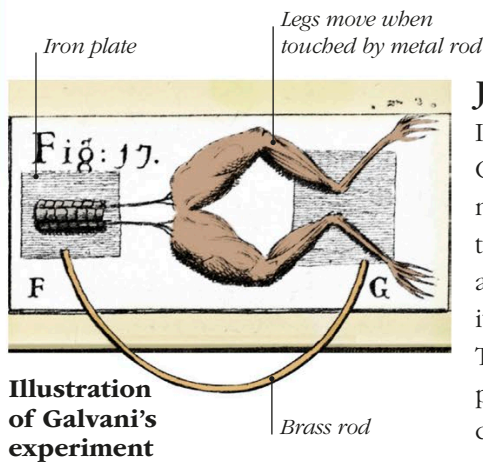


The battery

People have known about electricity for a long time. Ancient Greek scholars performed experiments with static electricity and, in the 18th century, the American inventor Benjamin Franklin proved lightning to be a form of electricity. But no one knew how to produce an electric current until the start of the 19th century, when the Italian scientist Alessandro Volta created the first battery.



JUMPING FROGS

In 1780, the Italian scientist Luigi Galvani found that he could make the muscles of a dead frog twitch, as if the animal were still alive, by touching the nerves in its legs with different metals. Thinking the force was being produced inside the frog, he called it “animal electricity.”

THE VOLTAIC PILE

Another Italian scientist, Alessandro Volta, thought Galvani's explanations were wrong. He believed the metals, not the animal, produced the electric current. To prove it, he created the world's first battery in 1800. This “Voltaic Pile” was made of piled groups of three disks—made of copper, cardboard soaked in seawater, and zinc.

